

CITIZENS' CONCERNS

- **Encroachments, including construction debris at eight locations, remain unaddressed despite the NGT's directive to clear floodplains**
- **The river rejuvenation project prioritises flood mitigation over ecological restoration, ignoring NGT's emphasis on reconnecting lakes and wetlands**
- **Experts oppose uniform widening and excessive dredging, stressing the need to retain natural silt and restore flora and fauna**

(CCV), comprising 20 environmental experts—had proposed detailed solutions to rejuvenate the river. The CSC's plan, which received in-principle government approval in 2008, included cleaning debris and creating a "bioshield" to prevent water from breaching the banks.

The Vadodara Municipal Corporation (VMC) even proposed a riverfront project inspired by Ahmedabad's Sabarmati Riverfront. However, environmentalist Rohit Prajapati, a CCV member, challenged the plan in the National Green Tribunal (NGT) in 2016, arguing for a holistic approach that wouldn't relocate reptiles and turtles. In 2021, the NGT ordered the restoration of the river's ecology and traditional waterways without disturbing aquatic life.

Bureaucratic red tape delayed progress until the 2024 flood forced action. A day after the floodwaters receded, chief minister Bhupendra Patel announced the ambitious Vishwamitri River Rejuvenation Project. The initiative aims to dredge and deepen the river, increase its carrying capacity by 1,100 cumecs, and reduce flooding risk by 51 per cent.

The VMC has to clean up a 24 km stretch of the river, while the state irrigation department will clean up another 24 km around the city. In January, the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority (SEIAA) approved the project while the Union ministry of environment, forest and climate change gave its nod for the temporary relocation of crocodiles and turtles.

But both citizen groups remain dissatisfied. "The VMC commissioner assured me the holistic plan would be taken up, but the focus seems limited to flood mitigation in the city alone," says Dr Mehta, who also leads the Vaho Vishwamitri Abhiyan, a people's movement to revive the river's entire 134 km stretch from Pavagadh to the Gulf of Khambhat.

A STUDY BY IIT GANDHINAGAR FOUND THE 2024 FLOOD WAS 'LIKELY EXACERBATED BY EXTENSIVE URBAN DEVELOPMENT IN FLOOD-PRONE AREAS'

CCV member Neha Sarwate highlights the gap between the NGT's order, on the basis of which the SEIAA approval was granted, and the current project. "The NGT emphasised restoring the river's meanders, reconnecting lakes and wetlands, and reinstating its ecology. This plan focuses on resectioning, dredging and desilting," she says.

The NGT also called for demarcating floodplains and removing unauthorised structures. "Eight locations that have been mapped with construction and demolition waste encroaching on the water body must be cleared. Restoring the entire stretch's flora, fauna and aquatic life is crucial. This is a river, not a canal," she adds. Prajapati, meanwhile, finds the approach to widen the river uniformly "flawed". "There's no need to remove natural silt to deepen the river, only remove debris...don't change its course," he asserts.

But VMC commissioner Dilip Kumar Rana maintains that the river is not being widened, while assuring that 66 waterways to drain rainwater will be restored, the river's natural course will be kept intact and the meander will not be disturbed beyond 3-5 per cent. "I don't find any unauthorised structures that need to be removed. Whichever such structures are there, we will remove them," he told INDIA TODAY.

Sameer Khera, president of the Heritage Trust Baroda, sees Vadodara's plight as symptomatic of India's unplanned urban development. "It's unfortunate that the locals had to withstand a flood for the obvious to be done. Vadodara is a city with active citizen participation in governance issues. It is a challenge to bring all stakeholders on board, but the cleanup must begin now," he says. For now, the people of Vadodara can only wait and hope the delays won't lead to another deluge. The clock is ticking, and the river's future—and alongside, the city's—seems to be flowing forward in trickles of grey. ■